ENGLISH C2 · ADVANCED GRAMMAR

Fronting and information structure

Fronting is not decoration. It changes the route through the message: the initial constituent becomes the frame from which the reader interprets what follows.

THE CENTRAL IDEA

Shape topic and focus by placing a motivated constituent in initial position.

Move a constituent to the opening position to establish topic, contrast or textual connection while controlling inversion and markedness.

MODEL

This constraint, we cannot ignore. / Rarely have I seen such care.

fronted constituent + clause | negative/restrictive fronting + auxiliary + subject

6 GUIDED STAGES · 29 LEARNING DECISIONS

This complete guide combines explanation, visual reasoning, practice and feedback. Separate exercise and answer-key editions are also available from the lesson page.

LEARNING OUTCOMES

Outcome 1	Outcome 2	Outcome 3
Distinguish topicalisation from contrastive and negative fronting.	Control inversion after restrictive negative expressions.	Use marked word order to organise real discourse rather than isolated sentences.

Build meaning before form

Move a constituent to the opening position to establish topic, contrast or textual connection while controlling inversion and markedness.

Topic comes before comment

In This constraint, we cannot ignore, the initial noun phrase establishes what the sentence is about; the remaining clause comments on it. The marked order is useful when the constraint is already active in the discourse.

Fronting therefore links sentence grammar to paragraph structure.

Contrastive fronting

A fronted complement can create a deliberate contrast: Useful it may be, but affordable it is not. The marked element receives prominence before the clause completes the evaluation.

Because this pattern is rhetorically strong, it needs a real contrast in the surrounding text.

Neutral	Marked
We cannot ignore this constraint.	This constraint, we cannot ignore.
The solution is elegant but costly.	Elegant the solution is, but it is costly.

When fronting triggers inversion

Negative and restrictive expressions such as rarely, only then, under no circumstances and not until trigger subject–auxiliary inversion. If no auxiliary is present, use do-support.

Ordinary object topicalisation does not trigger inversion: This book, I really enjoyed—not This book did I really enjoy.

Markedness must earn its place

Fronting guides attention, creates contrast or connects to prior discourse. Used without one of those functions, it can sound theatrical or obscure.

Compare the marked sentence with a neutral version and keep the fronted form only when it improves the information flow.

Reason through the pattern

The map separates the opening frame from the new-focus zone. A decision gate checks whether inversion is licensed by a negative or restrictive trigger.

01	02	03	04	05
fronted constituent	clause	negative/restrictive fronting	auxiliary	subject

DECIDE IN THIS ORDER

STEP 1

Decision 1

Decide what should function as the discourse frame.

STEP 2

Decision 2

Check whether the fronted element is topical, contrastive or restrictive.

STEP 3

Decision 3

Use subject–auxiliary inversion after negative and limiting expressions.

STEP 4

Decision 4

Return to neutral order when fronting adds no coherent discourse purpose.

Compare forms and meanings

Use the table to justify each structural choice.

Fronting type	Word order	Example
topicalisation	object + subject + verb	This issue, we can solve.
place/direction	adverbial + verb + subject	Into the room came the director.
negative/restrictive	phrase + auxiliary + subject	Rarely have we seen this.

EXAMPLES AT A GLANCE

This constraint	we cannot ignore
Rarely	have we seen...
Into the room	came the director

COMMON ERRORS

EDIT THIS

Avoid this pattern

Inverting after ordinary topicalisation.

EDIT THIS

Avoid this pattern

Forgetting inversion after a negative restrictive phrase.

EDIT THIS

Avoid this pattern

Fronting several elements until the sentence loses its focus.

Recognition in context

Choose the form that completes each situation naturally.

A1 · CONTEXT 1

The first proposal we can accept; ___.

OPTIONS the second we cannot · the second cannot we · cannot the second we · we the second cannot

A2 · CONTEXT 2

On the horizon ___ a line of dark clouds.

OPTIONS appeared · did appear there · they appeared · appeared there did

A3 · CONTEXT 3

Far more difficult ___ the final stage.

OPTIONS was · did · it was · was it

A4 · CONTEXT 4

This limitation, we ___ overlook.

OPTIONS cannot · cannot we · do cannot · not can

A5 · CONTEXT 5

Through the doorway ___ the missing witness.

OPTIONS walked · did walk · he walked · walked there

A6 · CONTEXT 6

Strange as it ___, the result was correct.

OPTIONS may seem · may it seem · seems it · does seem

STAGE CHECK

Pause before continuing

Underline the trigger or decision point, name the rule, and check that the meaning has not changed.

02 · PRACTICE STAGE

Two connected decisions

Resolve two connected choices within the same context.

B1 · CONNECTED CONTEXT 1

This argument, I _____; that conclusion, I _____.

OPTIONS Gap 1: accept / do accept it / accept it · Gap 2: reject / reject it / do it reject

B2 · CONNECTED CONTEXT 2

At the centre _____ a stone fountain; beside it _____ two ancient trees.

OPTIONS Gap 1: stood / did stand / it stood · Gap 2: grew / did grow / they grew

B3 · CONNECTED CONTEXT 3

More concerning _____ the lack of controls; equally serious _____ the absence of records.

OPTIONS Gap 1: was / it was / did · Gap 2: was / there was / did

STAGE CHECK

Pause before continuing

Underline the trigger or decision point, name the rule, and check that the meaning has not changed.

Guided text

Maintain the target structure throughout a complete text.

C1 · GUIDED APPLICATION

At the far end _____ a long table. On it _____ several sealed envelopes. These, the investigators _____ immediately; the notebooks, they _____ until later. Most striking _____ the complete absence of digital equipment.

_____
_____

WORD BANK

Available forms

did · did ignore them · did lie · did stand · did them examine · examined · examined them · ignored · ignored them · it stood · it was · lay · stood · they lay · was

STAGE CHECK

Pause before continuing

Underline the trigger or decision point, name the rule, and check that the meaning has not changed.

Open text

Supply every form without a word bank.

D1 · INDEPENDENT APPLICATION

We can accept this condition. -> This condition, _____. A narrow path ran through the forest. -> Through the forest _____. The final omission was most surprising. -> Most surprising _____. I will never compromise on that principle. -> That principle, _____. Two guards stood at the entrance. -> At the entrance _____.

_____
_____
_____
_____

STAGE CHECK

Pause before continuing

Underline the trigger or decision point, name the rule, and check that the meaning has not changed.

Controlled production

Transform the idea without changing its meaning.

E1 · CONTROLLED TASK 1

Front the first option: We can defend the first option.

_____
_____

E2 · CONTROLLED TASK 2

Write an original Fronting and information structure response for context 2. Include in the corner stood a lamp.

_____
_____

E3 · CONTROLLED TASK 3

Front “much more serious”: The second breach was much more serious.

_____
_____

E4 · CONTROLLED TASK 4

Correct: This issue, cannot we ignore.

_____
_____

STAGE CHECK

Pause before continuing

Underline the trigger or decision point, name the rule, and check that the meaning has not changed.

Communicative mission

Use the structure in original responses and realistic situations.

F1 · COMMUNICATION TASK 1

Write an original Fronting and information structure response for context 1. Include we support, we do not.

_____
_____
_____

F2 · COMMUNICATION TASK 2

Write an original Fronting and information structure response for context 2. Include stood, flickered.

_____
_____
_____

F3 · COMMUNICATION TASK 3

Write an original Fronting and information structure response for context 3. Include topic.

_____
_____
_____

Final self-check

Complete these prompts without reopening the guide.

R1 · REVIEW FOCUS

Explain and exemplify: topic.

_____
_____

R2 · REVIEW FOCUS

Explain and exemplify: focus.

_____
_____

R3 · REVIEW FOCUS

Explain and exemplify: inversion.

_____
_____

R4 · REVIEW FOCUS

Explain and exemplify: marked order.

_____
_____

R5 · REVIEW FOCUS

Apply this decision to a new example, then justify it: Decide what should function as the discourse frame..

_____
_____

R6 · REVIEW FOCUS

Apply this decision to a new example, then justify it: Check whether the fronted element is topical, contrastive or restrictive..

_____
_____

STAGE CHECK

Pause before continuing

Underline the trigger or decision point, name the rule, and check that the meaning has not changed.

Recognition in context

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

A1

the second we cannot

Use “the second we cannot”. Decide what should function as the discourse frame.

A2

appeared

Use “appeared”. Check whether the fronted element is topical, contrastive or restrictive.

A3

was

Use “was”. Use subject–auxiliary inversion after negative and limiting expressions.

A4

cannot

Use “cannot”. Return to neutral order when fronting adds no coherent discourse purpose.

A5

walked

Use “walked”. Decide what should function as the discourse frame.

A6

may seem

Use “may seem”. Check whether the fronted element is topical, contrastive or restrictive.

Two connected decisions

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

B1

accept / reject

Use “accept”. Decide what should function as the discourse frame. Use “reject”. Check whether the fronted element is topical, contrastive or restrictive.

B2

stood / grew

Use “stood”. Check whether the fronted element is topical, contrastive or restrictive. Use “grew”. Use subject–auxiliary inversion after negative and limiting expressions.

B3

was / was

Use “was”. Use subject–auxiliary inversion after negative and limiting expressions. Use “was”. Return to neutral order when fronting adds no coherent discourse purpose.

Guided text

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

C1

stood

Use “stood”. Decide what should function as the discourse frame.

C2

lay

Use “lay”. Check whether the fronted element is topical, contrastive or restrictive.

C3

examined

Use “examined”. Use subject–auxiliary inversion after negative and limiting expressions.

C4

ignored

Use “ignored”. Return to neutral order when fronting adds no coherent discourse purpose.

C5

was

Use “was”. Decide what should function as the discourse frame.

Open text

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

D1

we can accept

Use “we can accept”. Decide what should function as the discourse frame.

D2

ran a narrow path

Use “ran a narrow path”. Check whether the fronted element is topical, contrastive or restrictive.

D3

was the final omission

Use “was the final omission”. Use subject–auxiliary inversion after negative and limiting expressions.

D4

I will never compromise on

Use “I will never compromise on”. Return to neutral order when fronting adds no coherent discourse purpose.

D5

stood two guards

Use “stood two guards”. Decide what should function as the discourse frame.

Controlled production

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

E1

The first option, we can defend.

Use “The first option, we can defend.”. Decide what should function as the discourse frame.

E2

In the corner stood a lamp.

Use “In the corner stood a lamp.”. Check whether the fronted element is topical, contrastive or restrictive.

E3

Much more serious was the second breach.

Use “Much more serious was the second breach.”. Use subject–auxiliary inversion after negative and limiting expressions.

E4

This issue, we cannot ignore.

Use “This issue, we cannot ignore.”. Return to neutral order when fronting adds no coherent discourse purpose.

Communicative mission

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

F1

This recommendation, we support; the proposed timetable, we do not.

The model combines accurate Fronting and information structure with a clear purpose. Decide what should function as the discourse frame.

F2

Beyond the gate stood an empty house. In its windows flickered a pale light.

The model combines accurate Fronting and information structure with a clear purpose. Check whether the fronted element is topical, contrastive or restrictive.

F3

This constraint, we cannot ignore; “this constraint” is already active and becomes the topic.

The model combines accurate Fronting and information structure with a clear purpose. Use subject–auxiliary inversion after negative and limiting expressions.

07 · FEEDBACK

Diagnose the pattern, not only the score

Use this page to decide what to revisit in the complete guide.

CHECK · TRIGGER OR CONTEXT

What went wrong? What rule will prevent the same error next time?

_____
_____
_____

CHECK · AUXILIARY OR STRUCTURAL CHOICE

What went wrong? What rule will prevent the same error next time?

_____
_____
_____

CHECK · MAIN VERB OR CLAUSE FORM

What went wrong? What rule will prevent the same error next time?

_____
_____
_____

CHECK · MEANING AND REGISTER

What went wrong? What rule will prevent the same error next time?

_____
_____
_____

WELEARN STUDY SEQUENCE

01	02	03	04
complete guide	exercise workbook	answer key	retrieval review

RETRIEVAL

Final self-check

Complete these prompts without reopening the guide.